

Driver market jigsaw

Since Hamilton announced he would join Ferrari in one of the most high-profile driver transfers early this year, all eyes have been on the driver market. The move opened a coveted spot in Mercedes, which, despite its recent struggles, is one of the top teams on the grid.

But ahead of the Chinese GP, Fernando Alonso (right), a key player in the driver market, took himself out of contention when he signed a multi-year deal to stay at Aston Martin. While one domino has fallen, Mercedes has been aggressively courting Verstappen in recent weeks.

At the start of the season, there were rumours of discontent in Red Bull between team boss Christian Horner and its star driver Verstappen. At Shanghai, Horner blasted Merc team boss Toto Wolff for trying to poach his star driver and said Wolff should instead focus on improving his team's on-track performance.



AFP

Moto GP



REUTERS

If Formula One is predictable and one-way traffic, Moto GP is anything but, after Maverick Vinales became the third different winner this season in as many races.

The Spaniard was on song at the Motorcycle Grand Prix of the Americas in Austin, Texas, where he won both the sprint and main race. The Aprilia rider was on the money from the start of the weekend, taking pole position easily, three-tenths faster than rookie Pedro Acosta and Marc Marquez. On Saturday, Vinales put on a clinical performance in the 10-lap Sprint with a lights-to-flag victory ahead of Marc Marquez and Jorge Martin.

But it was his performance in the main race on Sunday that showed how good he was. Vinales had a poor start and fell to 11th on the opening lap, but over the next ten laps, breezed past the field with clinical precision. Even as Vinales was fighting back, Marquez looked set to get his first win for his new team, Gresini Racing MotoGP, when he took the lead at the halfway stage from Acosta. But just moments after he got ahead, the seven-time MotoGP champion, who had won the race in Austin a record seven times, lost control of his bike and crashed out.

It made the task easier for Vinales, who regained the lead eight laps before the chequered flag and cruised to his maiden win for Aprilia ahead of Acosta and Enea Bastianini of Ducati.

